

“Grant stood by me when I was crazy, and I stood by him when he was drunk, and now we stand by each other.”

William Sherman

come close to victory in 1862 and 1863 was a reflection of the Southern soldiers' profound belief in their cause. It was also the result of its plainly superior generals—the Virginian Robert E. Lee above all. By contrast, at least until the emergence of Ulysses S. Grant and William Sherman as the two leading commanders of the Union forces, the North had been able to muster only a succession of timid and inept generals who frittered away the advantages they so abundantly possessed.

Reinvigorated by Grant and Sherman, the North prevailed. The razing of Atlanta in September 1864 was followed by Sherman's “march to the sea” at Savannah, Georgia. Completed in December, it left a 60-mile- (96.5-km-) wide swathe of destruction, deliberately targeting civilian

property. “War is cruelty,” Sherman asserted. “The crueler it is, the sooner it will be over.”

A new freedom

The US Civil War was the world's first major industrial war, the first to make widespread use of railroads, and the first widely reported in a new kind of popular press. There was concentrated death on a scale never seen before: around 670,000 dead, 50,000 of them civilians, in little more than four years.

For Abraham Lincoln, the war represented what in the Gettysburg Address he called “unfinished business.” The Constitution had left unresolved the question of how slavery could exist in a nation “conceived in liberty.” Despite the destruction and the huge death toll, the war brought a chance at “a new birth of freedom.” The end of slavery, confirmed by the Thirteenth Amendment in 1865, represented an opportunity for the US to be recast as a genuinely free land for all its citizens, black and white. ■

This Thomas Nast illustration shows life for black Americans before and after emancipation. Abraham Lincoln is also portrayed.

